

NC.4 Where to File Directory

The offices a North Carolina owner-builder deals with, how to find each one for your parcel, and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. North Carolina permits are administered by 100 counties and dozens of municipalities, and local requirements vary. Confirm every item with the inspections department that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

WHO ISSUES YOUR PERMIT DEPENDS ON WHERE YOUR LOT IS

The building code is statewide; permits are not issued by the State. Both G.S. 87-14 and G.S. 160D-1110 send the application to *"the building inspector or other authority of any incorporated city, town, or county."* Inside a municipality's limits the city or town usually issues; in the unincorporated county, the county does — but some towns contract inspections back to the county.

Settle this first — it decides everything else

Before you gather a single document, confirm **which jurisdiction issues your permit** and whether your parcel is inside city limits or in the unincorporated county. Call the county inspections department with your parcel identification number (PIN) and ask them directly. Filing with the wrong office costs you weeks.

HOW TO FIND EACH OFFICE

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Building inspections (permits, plan review, inspection scheduling)	Search "[your county] NC building inspections" or "[your town] NC permits." Most NC jurisdictions run an online permit portal; ask which one and register before you file.
Planning / zoning (setbacks, use, zoning verification)	Often a separate department from inspections, sometimes the same counter. Ask inspections who confirms zoning and setbacks for your parcel — you will need that before plan review.
County health department (septic, private wells)	Search "[your county] NC environmental health." On-site wastewater and private drinking water wells are handled by the local health department, not the building inspector.

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
NCDOT District Engineer (driveway connection to a state-maintained road)	NCDOT runs 14 highway divisions with a county lookup at ncdot.gov → Divisions → Highways ; your driveway is handled by the District Engineer within that division. A permit is normally <i>not</i> required for a single residence — call anyway, they arrange the driveway pipe. First confirm your road is state-maintained at all.
Erosion & sedimentation control	If you will disturb more than one acre, this is either NC DEQ's land resources program or a delegated local program. Ask your inspections department which applies in your county — they cannot issue your building permit without an approved plan.

Permit-issuing authority: N.C.G.S. § 160D-1110(a) and § 87-14(a). Erosion control plan required before a building permit may issue for land-disturbing activity: § 160D-1110(e). Verified August 2026.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each entry by phone rather than copying it from a search result, and write the date you confirmed it. Note the name of the person you spoke to — in a county office, having a name is worth more than having a number.

BUILDING INSPECTIONS — issues the permit; schedules inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PLANNING / ZONING — setbacks, zoning verification, address assignment

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

COUNTY HEALTH — ENVIRONMENTAL HEALTH — septic and private well

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

NCDOT DISTRICT OFFICE — driveway access to a state-maintained road

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

EROSION & SEDIMENTATION CONTROL — if disturbing over one acre

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY — temporary construction power and permanent service

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

WATER & SEWER — public connection, tap fees — or N/A if well/septic

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

LIEN AGENT — required at \$40,000 or more — see NC.5

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing. Phone numbers are left for you to confirm — a wrong number printed in a kit is worse than no number.

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
NC Licensing Board for General Contractors	Verify that any contractor you hire at \$40,000 or more is licensed. This is also the body that receives your owner exemption affidavit and verifies your claim.	nclbgc.org
NC Office of State Fire Marshal Code enforcement / engineering	Publishes the North Carolina State Building Code and issues code interpretations. The place to settle a code dispute your inspector cannot.	ncosfm.gov
NC General Assembly	The General Statutes themselves — Chapter 87 (contractor licensing), Chapter 160D (development regulation, permits, inspections), Chapter 44A (liens).	ncleg.gov
NC Department of Insurance	Maintains the list of registered lien agents you must choose from (G.S. 44A-11.1(b), § 58-26-45).	ncdoi.gov

Sources (verified August 2026, all at ncleg.gov): permits issued by city, town, or county — § 160D-1110(a), § 87-14(a). Erosion control plan required before the building permit — § 160D-1110(e). Lien agent registry — § 44A-11.1(b), § 58-26-45. Affidavit forwarded to the Licensing Board — § 87-14(a)(1).